



John P. Carmichael

Manager tale often not long

Well, whadyuh know? Another major league manager has bit the dust as Grady Hatton joins Gene Mauch in the discard. Mauch had a long run at Philly, better than eight years, which is pretty good for these days. Even the President of the United States can't serve longer than that on an elected basis.

The Phils may have set a record of sorts for managerial changes in 1960. Eddie Sawyer was boss on the opening day of the season and resigned after losing to the Reds. Andy Cohen managed the team during the second game when they beat the Braves and Mauch arrived in time for the third game.

Walter Alston, of course, has far and away the best tenure of all managers today. He's in his 15th year with the Dodgers. But in the old days, the pilots hung up some longevity marks. Connie Mack managed (and owned) the Philly A's for 50 years. Hughie Jennings handled the Tigers for 13 straight seasons.

Miller Huggins (11), Joe McCarthy (14) and Casey Stengel (11) took care of the Yanks for 36 years and Jim Dykes lasted more than a decade with the White Sox. John McGraw was Mr. Giant for 28 years and fabled Wilbert Robinson survived in Brooklyn for 17 campaigns.

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THEY DIDN'T HAVE TO GET along with the players in those days; it was vice versa. Yet there were occasional rebellious souls and they crystalized into a cantankerous unit at Cleveland about 1940 against manager Oscar Vitt. They held indignation meetings. They complained to owner Alva Bradley. Writers and rival players had a series of "field days."

As the Indians would come out on a foreign diamond the taunts would begin. "Hey, Hemsley (Rollie) or Feller (Bob) or Trosky (Hal), have you told Vitt who's going to pitch today yet?" One May 1, traditional day for a big Communist parade in New York, Vitt opened a package and unfolded a solid red flag of oversized proportions. "You can carry this up to the plate today," read an enclosed message. Oscar always blamed Dykes, and he may have been right.

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ANYWHERE FROM 12 TO 20 Tribesmen were involved in the running battles with "Uncle Oz." There were enough disgruntled players to give every writer a shot at a story if he could get anybody to talk. Those also were the days when Dizzy Dean was making some copy with the Cubs and one day, Trosky, the Indian first baseman, cracked: "You Chicago guys think you have troubles with Dean. You ought to be with us and not know who of 25 guys to follow."

Eventually Vitt had to go — at the end of the '40 season — yet the Indians lost the pennant by just a single game in which Feller was beaten on a three hitter. They had only one man, outfielder Roy (Stormy) Weatherly hitting over .300. But in spite of the quarrelsome atmosphere, the boys decided to show Vitt they didn't need any morale help from him.

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THE REVOLT BROKE about June. The players threw the book at Oscar, charging he ridiculed their efforts, became personal in his remarks, failed to exercise calm judgment and additional alleged misdemeanors. The Cleveland nickname in the national press became the "Cry Babies." Vitt was a short fellow, with big eyes and big teeth — "the better to bite you with," said one player.

In a railroad diner one night a Cleveland pitcher was sitting with a newspaperman when Vitt and a couple of his coaches came in. The hurler caught sight of them. "There comes the so-and-so right now," he exploded in a loud voice and only the intervention of Oscar's aides prevented what could have been the culminating incident of a long, hot summer.

The story of Mauch's firing contained a sentence to the effect that Gene would be paid his full salary, estimated at \$50,000, for '68. Twenty-eight years ago, Vitt was getting a basic wage of \$15,000, plus promised raises of \$2,500 at a crack if attendance warranted. The Indians did draw 700,000 customers that year and Oscar pulled down 20 grand.

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YOU COULDN'T HIRE A MANAGER now for \$15,000 because even coaches get that much. But at the time \$15,000 to \$20,000 wasn't bad. Ty Cobb, for instance, started at \$1,500 for his first year at Detroit (1906) and got up to \$11,333 by 1913. Hans Wagner was paid \$2,500 in 1900 by the Pirates and made five figures by '08.

Buck Weaver of the White Sox went from \$1,800 in 1912 to \$6,000 in '18 and Ed Walsh, getting \$3,500 in 1908, got a bonus of the same amount for winning 40 games that year. Money must have been tight in those days.